

# Old-Timers Still Recall Great Day; Santa Rita Upset Chicago Cubs

By MARJORIE WHITE

Written Especially for Sunday  
Hard-nosed, semi-professional baseball was regular fare for fans in the mining country of southwestern New Mexico 50 years ago. That was in the heyday of the Copper League when Tyrone, Fort Bayard, El Paso, Hurley, and Santa Rita Teams vied for the pennant.

And the highlight of Copper League history is the day, April 5, 1918, when Santa Rita upset the visiting Chicago Cubs, who went on to win the National League championship that year. That was the day when the mighty bats of Santa Rita drove Grover Cleveland Alexander, baseball immortal, from the mound in the third inning.

It was a hard-fought game that was played that day in the shadow of the Kneeling Nun. It was nip and tuck for 10 innings until the Santa Ritans pushed across the run that won the contest for them, 6-5.

The Chicago team had stopped off at Santa Rita for a two-game exhibition series on the way back from their spring training camp on Catalina Island, off the southern California coast. And the Cubs got even with their hosts in the second game, April 6, by shutting them out, 6-0, before a crowd of 4,000 soldiers at Old Camp Cody, near Deming.

## NO ACCIDENT

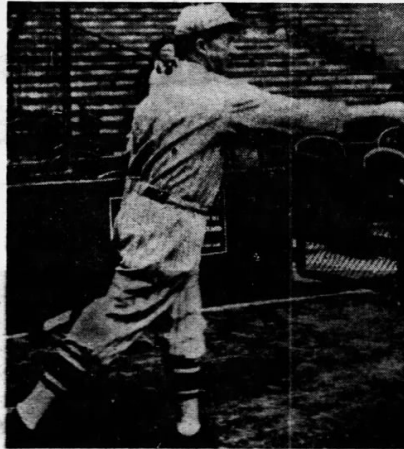
Santa Rita's victory was no fluke. They had a good team — fast and alert. Several of their players had been in the big leagues or would later become major leaguers. In the line-up that day were Adams, 1b; Truesdale, 2b; Fabrique, ss; Pezold, lf; Conroy, rf; Robertson, c; Sheehan, 3b; Bristow, cf; Burns, p; and Hendrix, p.

Second-base man Truesdale



**REMEMBERS**—Joe Hynes of Las Cruces, who played with Santa Rita in the great days of the Copper League, says the mining town teams "played the fastest baseball I've ever seen."

2 The Times Sunday Magazine



**KNOCKED HIM OUT**—Grover Cleveland Alexander, one of baseball's immortals, was knocked out of the box in the third inning, when the Santa Rita Copper League team defeated the visiting Chicago Cubs, April 5, 1918.

had been with the Browns, Yankees, and Red Sox in the American League. Short-stop Fabrique had played with Brooklyn in 1916-17. Left-fielder Pezold had been with the Cleveland Indians in 1914, and Bill Burns had pitched for the Senators, White Sox, Reds, Phillies, and Tigers. Third-baseman Sheehan was on his way up and later played with the Dodgers in 1920-21.

The Cubs held nothing back. They intended to win this game. They used their regular first-string line-up — players whose names were already in the record books: Charlie Holicher, ss; Max Flack, rf; Leslie Mann, lf; Dode Paskert, cf; Fred Merkle, 1b; Pete Kilduff, 2b; Charley Deal, 3b; and Bill Killifer, c. When the renowned Alexander left the game in the third inning, he was relieved by Claude Hendrix, who led the National League later that year with a 20-7 record.

Killifer, rated one of the best catchers in baseball history, and the famous Alexander were an imposing battery for Santa Rita to face. But the Copper Leaguers were ready and before the Chicago boys could rally from the third inning setback, the Santa Ritans had the game under control. When their starting pitcher, Hugh Harben, weakened in the seventh, Bill Burns took over to save the game for the Miners' nine.

A capacity crowd of 5,000 saw the game. Many of the fans came from other towns, transported on trains of flat-bed cars which made special runs. The weather was perfect — warm and sunny with not a trace of wind.

How did Santa Rita develop a team that could compete successfully against a big league outfit? The credit goes to the late Horace Moses, then Chino Mines superintendent. An ex-ballplayer himself and a great fan of the game, he made a

point of hiring good players. Some of them were on the way up to trying out in the big circuits and some were on the way down after having had a chance in the majors.

## TOP SLUGGER

Other Copper League teams also had some players whose names became nationally known. Bob Meusel, famous



**RESPONSIBLE**—The late Horace Moses, superintendent of the Chino Mines in heyday of the Copper League, promoted interest in the game by hiring good players.

New York Yankee slugging outfielder, broke in as a third baseman for Tyrone. He once hit the longest homerun ever seen in the Santa Rita ballpark, says Benny Bristow, center fielder for the Santa Rita team, now retired.

"I saw the ball sailing over my head and out of the park," he recalls. "I didn't bother to turn around. No need to chase that one."

Andy Cohen, veteran coach of the Sun Kings and former New York Giant second baseman (1926-29), played with the Hurley team early in his career. And Ralph Kiner, long-time great outfielder of the Pittsburgh Pirates, may have drawn his inspiration from the Copper League games he saw as a child. He was born in Santa Rita in 1922.

Fort Bayard won the Copper League pennant in 1926, with the help of some Chicago "Black Sox" who threw the World Series of 1919 to the Cincinnati Reds. Chick Gandil, Lefty Williams, and Buck Weaver were in the Bayard line-up that year, along with Hal Chase and Jimmie O'Connell of New York Giant fame, who had been banned from the majors under suspicion of complicity in throwing games.

"Those mining town teams played the fastest baseball I've ever seen," says Joe Hynes of Las Cruces, who played with Santa Rita in 1915-16 and in 1922. "The rivalry between teams in the Copper League produced spirited games and ardent fans. The copper-mining area was baseball-crazy in those days."



**PLAYER**—Benny Bristow, center fielder for Santa Rita in the memorable 1918 victory over the Chicago Cubs, lived for many years, until recently, on Ballpark Avenue in Santa Rita.

The day Pezold and Santa Rita beat the  
CHI Cubs! 4/5/18 (El Paso Times 4/3/66).

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